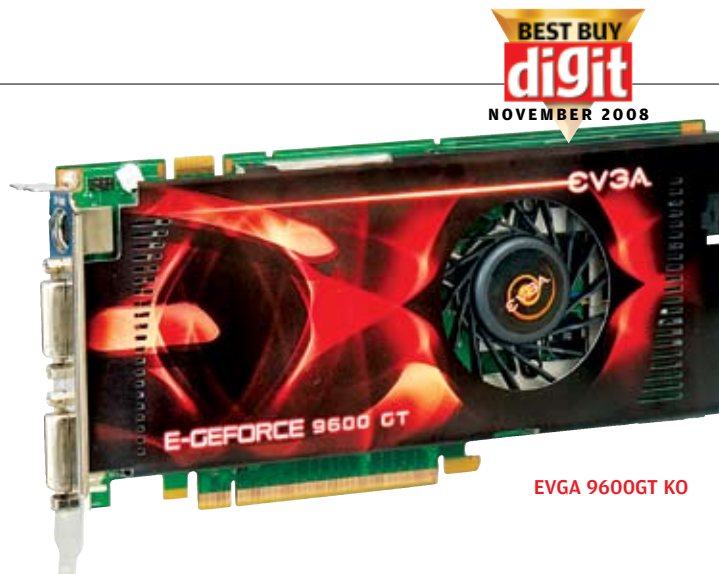


MSIs 9600 GT Zilent was unique – it had no fan, only a large heatsink with embedded heatpipes. Although HTPC users will appreciate the lack of a fan (read silence) the bulk of the cooling solution means you can't install this card inside a typically compact HTPC cabinet. EVGA was the only vendor to send us a card with NVIDIA's reference cooler – although this solution is adequate for the 9600 GT, there was a hike of around 10 degrees centigrade on the GPU core temperature when the card was stressed with benchmarks. All these vendors supplied the necessary cables to get you started and the *de facto* DVI to D-Sub connector. Palit was the only vendor who thought it worthwhile to bundle a game – their 9600 GT SONIC 1 GB came with *Tomb Raider Anniversary Edition*. This card also had HDMI and Display Port connectivity on the rear panel – a huge plus for anyone looking to hook this up to a large screen display. An optical out for audio was also provided – this is something

With two DVI connects, an HDMI port and a Display Port the Palit 9600 GT SONIC 1 GB is fully loaded. An optical out port is also provided for audio



EVGA 9600GT KO

new, that takes advantage of the inbuilt 7.1 audio decoding that all NVIDIA GeForce 8 and 9 series cards support.

Performance

All these cards feature GDDR3, although Palit's 9600 GT SONIC had 1 GB of video RAM, while the other two 9600 GTs had 512 MB each. The Palit 9600 GSO SONIC has 384 MB of 192-bit RAM. All the 9600 GTs had their cores clocked at a lively 700 MHz while the 9600 GSO had a core clock of 600 MHz. As expected

the 9600 GTs performed very closely to each other with very little to choose between them. The 9600 GSO trails some way behind in most benchmarks except in *Crysis* and *Company Of Heroes* which are shader intensive games. Here, presumably its lack of memory bandwidth is made up for by the extra SPs on the GPU, although it cannot overtake the trio of 9600 GTs. In terms of raw speed Palit's 9600 GT SONIC 1 GB was the fastest card amongst the foursome; EVGA trails by a hairsbreadth.

ative experience, this game has incredible detailing, expansive maps and an eerie kind of ambience, especially when roaming its environs at night. The bleak, scarred landscape is brought to life with some beautifully done shaders and texturing. A superb looking game.

Company Of Heroes: Opposing Fronts

One of the best looking RTS games, brilliant detailing, and very realistic enemy AI. An absolute gem of a game with eye candy to kill for.

World In Conflict

Perhaps the only RTS game that is the equivalent of *COH* in terms of visual appeal, this one has large scale, highly detailed battles.

F.E.A.R Perseus Mandate

Atmospheric, dark and gloomy and still unforgiving on older cards, *F.E.A.R.* is still the best in the business when it comes to close quarters firefights and scaring your lights out with some incredible visual effects. Great shadows, realistic combat, and very immersive.

3D Mark Vantage

Future Marks new 3D benchmarking standard, very taxing on older cards. Showcases DX10 shaders very well.

How We Tested

Test Configuration

CPU – Intel Core 2 Duo Extreme X6800 (2.93 GHz)
Motherboard – ASUS Rampage Extreme (Intel X48 Express Chipset)
RAM – 2 x 2 GB OCZ DDR3 1600 MHz
HDD – WD Raptor 80 GB (10,000 RPM, SATA)
Windows Vista Ultimate 64-bit
Monitor – Samsung SyncMaster 997DF

Below are the benchmarks we used, along with a brief description, if necessary.

Crysis

The most feared game for its ability to kill even the most powerful cards. One of the best looking games ever built, with great shader quality and amazingly realistic environments and effects, as well as incredibly detailed characters and gameplay. Visually stunning.

Unreal Tournament 3

Using the next gen *Unreal Engine 3*, *UT3* is a game not to be missed. Its faster than its predecessors, and visually splendid too.

S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Shadow Of Chernobyl

The X-Ray engine by GSC gameworld – an open ended explor-

GeForce 9500 GT

Kill the middleman

NVIDIA's GeForce 9500 GT – the replacement to the GeForce 8500 GT is basically an entry level solution that should be kept away from all but the most cash deprived gaming PCs. This card is meant for a multimedia PC or an HTPC – these usage patterns suit its limited 3D performance better. Based around 32 SPs and a 128-bit memory interface the 9500 GT is a single slot card that does not require additional power over and above what the PCIe bus can supply. These cards are 65 nm parts so heat isn't an issue. We were surprised to see all the 9500 GT-based cards were full profile ones. In our



Palit 9600 GT 1GB SONIC

opinion an HTPC should ideally utilise a half profile card since most HTPC cabinets are really tiny.

Features

We had a round figure of ten 9500 GT-based cards. Calibre

had the most attractive looking 9500 GT; their card has a neat looking heatpipe cooling solution that is reasonably compact and utilises a small fan. The only downside is that the card is noticeably heavier than the stock cooling solution. In terms of cable and connect bundling Palit and POV were the two main culprits – their bundling was rather skimpy. Sadly none of the vendors thought it important to bundle any games with these cards. Since this cuts into their margins; it's understandable why such exclusions are made for what are perceived as value cards. The Calibre 9500 GT has a display panel bundled that gives important information on the clock speeds of the card.

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